SPANISH GRAMMAR

El Presente de Indicativo

From regular verbs, through the stem and spelling changes, to the twelve true irregulars and the reflexives.

A WORKING REFERENCE

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- **Gold** marks the **ending** that is added to the stem.
- **Red** marks a **stem change** or an irregular letter.
- **Teal** marks a **spelling change** made to preserve pronunciation.
- Greyed-out rows are the forms where a change **does not** happen.

0 What the Present Tense Is Used For

EL PRESENTE — USOS

The Spanish present covers more ground than the English simple present. One Spanish form does the work of several English ones, which is why a literal translation often sounds wrong in one direction or the other.

The five main uses

USE	EXAMPLE	ENGLISH
Habitual actions	***Trabajo desde casa.***	I work from home.
Happening right now no progressive needed	***¿Qué haces? — Leo.***	What are you doing? — I'm reading.
The near future with a time expression	***Mañana salgo a las ocho.***	Tomorrow I leave at eight.
Ongoing situations English uses the perfect	***Hace tres años que vivo aquí.***	I have lived here for three years.
Narrating the past vividly historical present	***En 1492 Colón llega a América.***	In 1492 Columbus arrives in America.

The six persons

PERSON	PRONOUN	NOTE
1st singular	**yo**	—
2nd singular	**tú**	informal
3rd singular	**él / ella / usted**	*usted* is formal "you" but takes the 3rd person form
1st plural	**nosotros / nosotras**	—
2nd plural	**vosotros / vosotras**	Spain only
3rd plural	**ellos / ellas / ustedes**	in Latin America *ustedes* replaces *vosotros* entirely

SUBJECT PRONOUNS ARE USUALLY DROPPED

The ending already tells you who the subject is. *Hablo* can only mean "I speak", so *yo* is left out unless you are contrasting or emphasising.

1 Regular Verbs

VERBOS REGULARES

Every Spanish infinitive ends in **-ar**, **-er**, or **-ir**. To conjugate a regular verb you remove those last two letters to get the **stem** — *hablar* → **habl-**, *comer* → **com-**, *abrir* → **abr-** — then add the ending for the person you want.

The three sets of endings

PERSON	-AR *hablar · to speak*	-ER *comer · to eat*	-IR *abrir · to open*
yo	habl**o**	com**o**	abr**o**
tú	habl**as**	com**es**	abr**es**
él / ella / usted	habl**a**	com**e**	abr**e**
nosotros	habl**amos**	com**emos**	**abrimos**
vosotros	habl**áis**	com**éis**	**abrís**
ellos / ellas / ustedes	habl**an**	com**en**	abr**en**

THE SINGLE MOST USEFUL OBSERVATION

-ER and **-IR** verbs are identical except in the *nosotros* and *vosotros* forms, marked in gold above. Those two forms are the only place in the whole present tense where the -er/-ir distinction shows up at all.

Hablo español con mi familia.
I speak Spanish with my family.
Comemos a la una.
We eat at one.
Abren la tienda a las nueve.
They open the shop at nine.

Points worth fixing in memory

- The **yo** form always ends in **-o** for regular verbs, no matter the group.
- The **vosotros** form always carries a written accent: *habláis, coméis, abrís*.
- The *nosotros* form of **-ar** and **-ir** verbs (*hablamos, abrimos*) is identical to the preterite form. Context tells you which one is meant.

2 Stem-Changing Verbs

VERBOS CON CAMBIO EN LA RAÍZ

In these verbs the **endings stay completely regular**. What changes is the last vowel of the stem, and only when that vowel is stressed.

The stress falls on the stem in four of the six forms: *yo, tú, él, ellos*. It falls on the ending in *nosotros* and *vosotros*. So the change happens in four forms and not in the other two.

yo	**changed**
tú	**changed**
él / ella / usted	**changed**
nosotros	unchanged
vosotros	unchanged
ellos / ellas / ustedes	**changed**

Laid out in a column, the changed forms wrap around the unchanged middle in an L-shape. This is why they are commonly called **boot verbs** or **shoe verbs**. The same shape governs every pattern in this section.

A STEM CHANGE CANNOT BE PREDICTED

Nothing in the infinitive tells you whether a verb changes its stem. Dictionaries mark it explicitly, for example *pensar (ie)* or *dormir (ue)*. Learn the marking together with the verb.

2.1 E → IE

The most common stem change. The stressed **e** of the stem becomes **ie**.

PENSAR to think — E → IE

yo	p**ie**nso
tú	p**ie**nsas
él / ella / usted	p**ie**nsa
nosotros	pensamos
vosotros	pensáis
ellos / ellas / ustedes	p**ie**nsan

OTHER VERBS IN THIS GROUP

VERB	YO FORM	MEANING	VERB	YO FORM	MEANING
querer	**quiero**	to want / to love	*sentir*	**siento**	to feel
empezar	**empiezo**	to begin	*preferir*	**prefiero**	to prefer
comenzar	**comienzo**	to begin	*despertar*	**despierto**	to wake
entender	**entiendo**	to understand	*recomendar*	**recomiendo**	to recommend
perder	**pierdo**	to lose	*mentir*	**miento**	to lie
cerrar	**cierro**	to close	*nevar*	**nieva**	to snow — 3rd pers. only

One verb goes further: **adquirir** changes **i → ie** (*adquiero*). So does **jugar**, covered in 2.5.

2.2 Accent additions

A small group of verbs ending in **-iar** and **-uar** do not change their vowel, but they do move the stress onto it. That stress has to be written as an accent, which breaks the vowel away from the one next to it so it becomes its own syllable.

PERSON	ENVIAR — I → Í *to send*	CONTINUAR — U → Ú *to continue*
yo	envío	continúo
tú	envías	continúas
él / ella / usted	envía	continúa
nosotros	enviamos	continuamos
vosotros	enviáis	continuáis
ellos / ellas / ustedes	envían	continúan

Same L-shaped pattern as the vowel changes: four forms accented, *nosotros* and *vosotros* not.

I → Í	U → Ú
enviar → **envío**	continuar → **continúo**
confiar → **confío**	actuar → **actúo**
guiar → **guío**	graduar → **gradúo**
variar → **varío**	situar → **sitúo**
esquiar → **esquío**	evaluar → **evalúo**
espiar → **espío**	acentuar → **acentúo**

Also in this family: **reunir** → *reúno*, **prohibir** → *prohíbo*, **aislar** → *aíslo*.

MOST -IAR VERBS TAKE NO ACCENT AT ALL

The majority of **-iar** verbs are simply regular. Compare:

- *estudiar* → **estudio**, estudias, estudia — no accent
- *cambiar* → **cambio**, cambias, cambia — no accent
- *enviar* → **envío**, envías, envía — accent

There is no rule to tell these apart. They have to be learned individually.

2.3 O → UE

The stressed **o** of the stem becomes **ue**.

PODER to be able to, can — O → UE

yo	puedo
tú	puedes
él / ella / usted	puede
nosotros	podemos
vosotros	podéis
ellos / ellas / ustedes	pueden

OTHER VERBS IN THIS GROUP

VERB	YO FORM	MEANING	VERB	YO FORM	MEANING
volver	**vuelvo**	to return	*morir*	**muero**	to die
dormir	**duermo**	to sleep	*probar*	**pruebo**	to try / to taste
contar	**cuento**	to count / to tell	*almorzar*	**almuerzo**	to have lunch
encontrar	**encuentro**	to find	*mover*	**muevo**	to move
recordar	**recuerdo**	to remember	*resolver*	**resuelvo**	to solve
mostrar	**muestro**	to show	*soler*	**suelo**	to usually do
costar	**cuesta**	to cost — 3rd pers. only	*llover*	**llueve**	to rain — 3rd pers. only

2.4 E → I

The stressed **e** of the stem becomes **i**. This change happens **only in -ir verbs**.

PEDIR to ask for, to order — E → I

yo	p**i**do
tú	p**i**des
él / ella / usted	p**i**de
nosotros	pedimos
vosotros	pedís
ellos / ellas / ustedes	p**i**den

OTHER VERBS IN THIS GROUP

VERB	YO FORM	MEANING	VERB	YO FORM	MEANING
servir	**sirvo**	to serve	*competir*	**compito**	to compete
repetir	**repito**	to repeat	*impedir*	**impido**	to prevent
vestir	**visto**	to dress	*freír*	**frío**	to fry
medir	**mido**	to measure	*reír*	**río**	to laugh
despedir	**despido**	to dismiss / to see off	*sonreír*	**sonrío**	to smile

TWO DETAILS

reír and *sonreír* combine the vowel change with a written accent: **río, ríes, ríe, reímos, reís, ríen**.

Two very common verbs, **seguir** and **decir**, belong to this group but also have an irregular *yo* form. They are covered in sections 3.5 and 4.

2.5 U → UE

Exactly one verb in the language does this.

JUGAR to play (games, sports) — U → UE

yo	j**ue**go
tú	j**ue**gas
él / ella / usted	j**ue**ga
nosotros	jugamos
vosotros	jugáis
ellos / ellas / ustedes	j**ue**gan

Juego al fútbol los sábados.
I play football on Saturdays.

2.6 Adding Y — the -uir verbs

Verbs ending in **-uir** insert a **y** between the stem and the ending, in the same four boot forms. This exists so the *u* and the following vowel do not collapse into one sound.

CONSTRUIR to build — ADDS Y

yo	construyo
tú	construyes
él / ella / usted	construye
nosotros	construimos
vosotros	construís
ellos / ellas / ustedes	construyen

OTHER VERBS IN THIS GROUP

VERB	YO FORM	MEANING	VERB	YO FORM	MEANING
incluir	**incluyo**	to include	*contribuir*	**contribuyo**	to contribute
destruir	**destruyo**	to destroy	*distribuir*	**distribuyo**	to distribute
huir	**huyo**	to flee	*sustituir*	**sustituyo**	to substitute
concluir	**concluyo**	to conclude	*atribuir*	**atribuyo**	to attribute
influir	**influyo**	to influence			

NOT THE SAME AS -GUIR

Verbs ending in **-guir** (*seguir*, *distinguir*) are **not** in this group. The *u* there is silent and only exists to keep the *g* hard. See section 3.5.

3 Irregular YO Forms

PRIMERA PERSONA IRREGULAR

These verbs are regular in five of the six forms. Only the **yo** form is irregular, and it is irregular for a reason: either the spelling has to change to keep the pronunciation consistent before the **-o** ending, or the verb simply takes an extra letter.

CHANGES STACK

If a verb also has a stem change from section 2, that stem change still applies on top of the irregular *yo* form. *Seguir* is both e → i and a -guir verb; *elegir* is both e → i and g → j.

3.1 C → ZC

Verbs ending in **-cer** or **-cir** where the letter before the *c* is a **vowel**.

CONOCER to know a person or place — C → ZC

YO	TÚ	ÉL / ELLA / USTED	NOSOTROS	VOSOTROS	ELLOS / ELLAS / USTEDES
conozco	conoces	conoce	conocemos	conocéis	conocen

VERB	YO FORM	MEANING	VERB	YO FORM	MEANING
parecer	**parezco**	to seem	*pertenecer*	**pertenezco**	to belong
ofrecer	**ofrezco**	to offer	*merecer*	**merezco**	to deserve
agradecer	**agradezco**	to thank	*reconocer*	**reconozco**	to recognise
aparecer	**aparezco**	to appear	*conducir*	**conduzco**	to drive
crecer	**crezco**	to grow	*traducir*	**traduzco**	to translate
nacer	**nazco**	to be born	*producir*	**produzco**	to produce
obedecer	**obedezco**	to obey	*introducir*	**introduzco**	to introduce / insert

RULE OF THUMB

This is a large and productive group. If you meet a new verb ending in a vowel plus **-cer** or **-cir**, assume **-zco**.

3.2 C → Z

Verbs ending in **-cer** or **-cir** where the letter before the *c* is a **consonant**.

The *c* in *vencer* is soft because it sits before *e*. Before the *o* of the yo ending it would turn hard, so it is written **z** instead, which keeps the soft sound.

VENCER to defeat, to expire — C → Z

YO	TÚ	ÉL / ELLA / USTED	NOSOTROS	VOSOTROS	ELLOS / ELLAS / USTEDES
venzo	vences	vence	vencemos	vencéis	vencen

VERB	YO FORM	MEANING
convencer	**convenzo**	to convince
ejercer	**ejerzo**	to practise a profession
esparcir	**esparzo**	to scatter
torcer	**tuerzo**	to twist — also o → ue
cocer	**cuezo**	to boil, to cook — also o → ue

3.3 G → J

Verbs ending in **-ger** or **-gir**. Same logic as the previous rule: the *g* is soft before *e* and *i*, so before the *o* of the yo ending it is written **j** to keep that sound.

COGER to take, to catch — G → J

YO	TÚ	ÉL / ELLA / USTED	NOSOTROS	VOSOTROS	ELLOS / ELLAS / USTEDES
cojo	coges	coge	cogemos	cogéis	cogen

VERB	YO FORM	MEANING	VERB	YO FORM	MEANING
escoger	**escojo**	to choose	*exigir*	**exijo**	to demand
recoger	**recojo**	to pick up	*fingir*	**finjo**	to pretend
proteger	**protejo**	to protect	*elegir*	**elijo**	to choose — also e → i
dirigir	**dirijo**	to direct / to manage	*corregir*	**corrijo**	to correct — also e → i

3.4 Adding G

A group of common verbs simply inserts a **g** in the yo form. There is no pronunciation reason for it; it has to be memorised. These are often called **-go verbs**.

SALIR to leave, to go out — ADDS G

YO	TÚ	ÉL / ELLA / USTED	NOSOTROS	VOSOTROS	ELLOS / ELLAS / USTEDES
salgo	sales	sale	salimos	salís	salen

VERB	YO FORM	NOTE
poner	**pongo**	also *suponer* → supongo, *proponer* → propongo
valer	**valgo**	—
hacer	**hago**	the *c* is replaced by *g*
traer	**traigo**	inserts **ig**
caer	**caigo**	inserts **ig**
tener	**tengo**	also stem-changing e → ie in other forms
venir	**vengo**	also stem-changing e → ie in other forms
decir	**digo**	also stem-changing e → i in other forms
oír	**oigo**	also adds **y** in other forms

The first five (*poner, valer, hacer, traer, caer*) are regular everywhere except the yo form. The last four are fully irregular and appear again in section 4.

3.5 The -GUIR verbs

In **-guir** verbs the *u* is silent. It is only there to keep the *g* hard before *e* and *i*. Before the *o* of the yo ending the *g* is already hard, so the *u* is dropped.

SEGUIR to follow, to continue — GU → G

yo	**sigo**
tú	**sigues**
él / ella / usted	**sigue**
nosotros	seguimos
vosotros	seguís
ellos / ellas / ustedes	**siguen**

Seguir shows both changes at once: the stem change **e → i** in the boot forms, and the spelling change **gu → g** in the yo form only.

VERB	YO FORM	MEANING
conseguir	**consigo**	to get / to obtain
perseguir	**persigo**	to chase / to pursue
distinguir	**distingo**	to distinguish — no stem change
extinguir	**extingo**	to extinguish — no stem change

distinguir and *extinguir* show the spelling rule on its own: the only change is the dropped *u*.

3.6 Other — Saber and Caber

Two verbs have a yo form that fits no pattern at all.

PERSON	SABER *to know facts, to know how to*	CABER *to fit*
yo	**sé**	**quepo**
tú	sabes	cabes
él / ella / usted	sabe	cabe
nosotros	sabemos	cabemos
vosotros	sabéis	cabéis
ellos / ellas / ustedes	saben	caben

sé carries a written accent to distinguish it from the pronoun *se*.

TWO MORE THAT BELONG HERE

ver → *veo* and **dar** → *doy* are usually listed as fully irregular, but in the present tense they change in the yo form only. Both are otherwise regular.

4 Fully Irregular Verbs

VERBOS IRREGULARES

These twelve change in more than just the yo form. They are also the most frequently used verbs in the language, so the effort of memorising them pays off immediately.

Ser, estar and ir

The three whose present forms barely resemble their infinitive. *Ir* in particular comes from a different Latin verb, which is why it shares no letters with its own infinitive.

PERSON	SER *to be — identity, origin*	ESTAR *to be — location, state*	IR *to go*
yo	**soy**	**estoy**	**voy**
tú	**eres**	est**á**s	**vas**
él / ella / usted	**es**	est**á**	**va**
nosotros	**somos**	estamos	**vamos**
vosotros	**sois**	est**á**is	**vais**
ellos / ellas / ustedes	**son**	est**á**n	**van**

Estar carries a written accent on every form except *yo* and *nosotros*.

Soy de Bélgica. Ella es ingeniera.
I am from Belgium. She is an engineer.
Estoy cansado. El libro está en la mesa.
I am tired. The book is on the table.

IR + A + INFINITIVE

This is the standard way to express the near future.

> ***Voy a estudiar esta noche.***
> I am going to study tonight.

Tener, querer and decir

All three are stem-changing. *Tener* and *decir* add the irregular *-go* yo form on top; *querer* is a plain boot verb in the present and only turns irregular in other tenses (*quise, querré*).

PERSON	TENER — E → IE *to have*	QUERER — E → IE *to want, to love*	DECIR — E → I *to say, to tell*
yo	teng**o**	qu**ie**ro	d**ig**o
tú	t**ie**nes	qu**ie**res	d**i**ces
él / ella / usted	t**ie**ne	qu**ie**re	d**i**ce
nosotros	tenemos	queremos	decimos
vosotros	tenéis	queréis	decís
ellos / ellas / ustedes	t**ie**nen	qu**ie**ren	d**i**cen

The *tener* pattern carries over to *mantener, obtener, contener, detener*.

TENER WHERE ENGLISH USES "TO BE"

Spanish uses *tener* for age, hunger, thirst, cold, fear and sleepiness: *Tengo treinta años* (I am thirty), *tengo hambre* (I am hungry), *tengo frío* (I am cold).

Oír — to hear

YO	TÚ	ÉL / ELLA / USTED	NOSOTROS	VOSOTROS	ELLOS / ELLAS / USTEDES
oigo	oyes	oye	oímos	oís	oyen

Three things at once: an irregular yo form (*-igo*), a **y** inserted in the boot forms, and a written accent on *oímos* and *oís* to keep the *o* and *i* in separate syllables.

Haber — to have (auxiliary) · there is, there are

YO	TÚ	ÉL / ELLA / USTED	NOSOTROS	VOSOTROS	ELLOS / ELLAS / USTEDES
he	**has**	**ha**	**hemos**	habéis	**han**

Haber is almost never used on its own. It has two jobs:

1. **Auxiliary for the perfect tense**, always followed by a past participle.
2. **Impersonal "there is / there are"**, in the special form **hay**, which never changes for number.

He comido. ¿Has visto la película?
I have eaten. Have you seen the film?
Hay un problema. Hay tres sillas.
There is a problem. There are three chairs.

Poner, hacer, ver and dar — the yo form only

These four are regular in five of the six forms. Learning the yo form is all that is required.

PERSON	PONER *to put*	HACER *to do, to make*	VER *to see*	DAR *to give*
yo	pongo	hago	veo	**doy**
tú	pones	haces	ves	das
él / ella / usted	pone	hace	ve	da
nosotros	ponemos	hacemos	vemos	damos
vosotros	ponéis	hacéis	veis	dais
ellos / ellas / ustedes	ponen	hacen	ven	dan

- The *poner* pattern carries over to *suponer, proponer, componer, imponer*.
- *Hacer* is also the weather verb: *Hace frío. Hace sol. Hace viento.*
- *Ver* keeps the *e* of the old infinitive *veer*, which is why the yo form is *veo* and not *vo*.
- *veis* and *dais* take no accent, unlike most *vosotros* forms.

THE FOUR VERBS ENDING IN -OY

soy · estoy · voy · doy

THESE ARE THE ONLY FOUR IN THE ENTIRE LANGUAGE

5 Reflexive Verbs

VERBOS REFLEXIVOS

A reflexive verb is one where the subject and the object are the same person. The infinitive is marked with **-se** on the end: *lavarse, levantarse, llamarse.*

The reflexive pronouns

YO	TÚ	ÉL / ELLA / USTED	NOSOTROS	VOSOTROS	ELLOS / ELLAS / USTEDES
me	**te**	**se**	**nos**	**os**	**se**

How to conjugate

1. Drop the **-se** and conjugate the verb exactly as you normally would, applying any stem change or irregular yo form.
2. Put the matching reflexive pronoun **before** the conjugated verb.

LLAMARSE to be called — REFLEXIVE

yo	**me** llamo
tú	**te** llamas
él / ella / usted	**se** llama
nosotros	**nos** llamamos
vosotros	**os** llamáis
ellos / ellas / ustedes	**se** llaman

¿Cómo te llamas? — Me llamo Ana.
What is your name? — My name is Ana.

LEVANTARSE to get up — REFLEXIVE

YO	TÚ	ÉL / ELLA / USTED	NOSOTROS	VOSOTROS	ELLOS / ELLAS / USTEDES
me levanto	**te** levantas	**se** levanta	**nos** levantamos	**os** levantáis	**se** levantan

Stem changes still apply

Making a verb reflexive changes nothing about the conjugation itself.

INFINITIVE	YO FORM	PATTERN
despertarse	**me despierto**	e → ie
sentarse	**me siento**	e → ie
acostarse	**me acuesto**	o → ue
dormirse	**me duermo**	o → ue
vestirse	**me visto**	e → i
despedirse	**me despido**	e → i
ponerse	**me pongo**	irregular yo form
irse	**me voy**	fully irregular

A COLLISION WORTH KNOWING

Two of these produce the same yo form and have to be told apart by context:

- *me siento* from **sentarse** — I sit down
- *me siento* from **sentirse** — I feel

> ***Me siento en la silla porque no me siento bien.***
> I sit down on the chair because I do not feel well.

Where the pronoun goes

STRUCTURE	RULE	EXAMPLE
Conjugated verb	Pronoun before the verb	***Me*** *ducho por la noche.*
Negative	Pronoun stays with the verb, *no* goes first	***No me*** *ducho por la mañana.*
Infinitive	Attach to the end, or place before the first verb	*Voy a ducharme. / **Me** voy a duchar.*
Gerund	Attach to the end, or place before the first verb	*Estoy duchándo**me**. / **Me** estoy duchando.*
Affirmative command	Must attach to the end	*Dúcha**te**.*
Negative command	Must go before the verb	*No **te** duches.*

WHY THE ACCENTS APPEAR

When a pronoun is attached to a gerund or a command, the stress of the original word does not move. A written accent is added to preserve it: *duchándome, dúchate, levántate, siéntese.*

Body parts and clothing take the definite article

Where English uses a possessive, Spanish uses *el / la / los / las*. The reflexive pronoun already tells you whose it is.

> ***Me lavo las manos.***
> I wash my hands.
> ***Se quita el abrigo.***
> He takes off his coat.
> ***Nos cepillamos los dientes.***
> We brush our teeth.

The pronoun can also be reciprocal

In the plural, *nos* and *se* can mean “each other” instead of “oneself”.

Nos vemos mañana.
We'll see each other tomorrow.
Se escriben todas las semanas.
They write to each other every week.

The reflexive form can change the meaning

For many verbs, adding the pronoun is not just a grammatical detail; it produces a different verb.

PLAIN	REFLEXIVE
ir — to go	**irse** — to leave / to go away
dormir — to sleep	**dormirse** — to fall asleep
acordar — to agree	**acordarse** — to remember
llevar — to carry	**llevarse** — to get along / to take away
poner — to put	**ponerse** — to put on / to become
volver — to return	**volverse** — to become
parecer — to seem	**parecerse** — to look alike
quedar — to be left	**quedarse** — to stay
dar — to give	**darse cuenta** — to realise

Duermo ocho horas.
I sleep eight hours.
Me duermo a las once.
I fall asleep at eleven.

REFLEXIVE ONLY

Some verbs exist in no other form: *arrepentirse* (to regret), *atreverse* (to dare), *quejarse* (to complain), *suicidarse*.

6 Summary

RESUMEN

CATEGORY	WHAT CHANGES	WHICH FORMS
Regular	nothing	—
Stem change e → ie, o → ue, e → i, u → ue	stem vowel	**all except nosotros / vosotros**
Accent addition (-iar, -uar)	written accent on stem vowel	**all except nosotros / vosotros**
Adding y (-uir)	y inserted	**all except nosotros / vosotros**
c → zc, c → z, g → j, adding g, -guir	spelling or extra letter	**yo only**
Fully irregular	several forms	**varies**
Reflexive	pronoun added	**all six**

THE ONE THING TO TAKE AWAY

The endings themselves are never irregular, with the single exception of the twelve verbs in section 4. Everything else is a change to the **stem**.